

10

Platforms, Misinformation, Disinformation, and Propaganda

Chapter 10 focuses on a set of current issues of central concern to contemporary democracies – namely, the relationship between information, polarization, mis/disinformation, propaganda, and public opinion. We define, theorize, and historicize these concepts, and discuss the types of information the public needs in democratic and other states. The chapter considers the role that fact-producing institutions play in political life, and asks what roles they should play. And we consider the responsibilities that platforms, journalism, and governments have for creating robust, democratic communication environments.

OBJECTIVES

By the end of this chapter, you should be able to:

- understand the relationship between platforms, information, and polarization
- explain concepts such as mis- and disinformation and propaganda
- consider how we can strengthen democratic information environments.

10.1 Introduction

“The Pope endorses Donald Trump for U.S. President!” screamed a Facebook post in the run-up to the US presidential election in 2016. In a world before Donald Trump was elected president of the United States, many dismissed this inconceivable bit of “fake news” as a joke. Who, after all, could seriously believe that the Argentine pope, widely seen as a reformer of the conservative Catholic Church, with his comparatively permissive views on homosexuality and embrace of welcoming refugees and being anti-poverty and anti-climate change, would publicly back the conservative, populist US presidential candidate who openly disparaged immigrants in racist terms?

In the years since, however, this particular piece of monetized “fake news” appears quite different: a harbinger of the deep threats to democracies around the world that would come into view in subsequent years. With the global rise of right-wing, populist, and authoritarian candidates and leaders – such as Viktor Orbán in Hungary and Jair Bolsonaro, who led Brazil until December 2022 – the spread of international conspiracy movements such as QAnon (Marwick & Partin 2022), anti-vaccine and health misinformation during the global Covid-19 pandemic (Gadarian et al. 2022), and the attempted coup at the US

Capitol on January 6, 2021, many researchers, journalists, policymakers, and platforms themselves grew increasingly concerned about misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda on platforms as fundamental threats to democracy, including the potential role of these things in increasing polarization between various groups in society (Finkel et al. 2020).

In January 2018, in an interview with David Letterman, even former US President Barack Obama weighed in:

If you are getting all your information off algorithms being sent through your phone and it's just reinforcing whatever biases you have, which is the pattern that develops, at a certain point, you just live in a bubble, and that's part of why our politics is so polarized right now. I think it's a solvable problem, but I think it's one we have to spend a lot of time thinking about.

(Hamedy 2018)

While the research about the role of mis- and disinformation and propaganda in contemporary democratic crises across the world is deep, and deeply contested (for reviews, see Bennett & Livingston 2020; Jerit & Zhao 2020; Persily & Tucker 2020), virtually no one would doubt the increasing prevalence of information warfare on platforms being waged in, and between, countries around the world. This includes information warfare by states and groups vying for political power (Anderson 2021; Freelon & Wells 2020; Ong & Cabañes 2018). As a reminder, the idea of “democratic backsliding” refers to the general erosion of the institutions and norms of democracy (Levitsky & Ziblatt 2018), often in small ways that, taken together, undermine elections, the balance of powers, and the rule of law. Scholars broadly suggest that democratic backsliding or crises more generally occur because of polarization, declines in tolerance and faith in democracy among the public, growing views of the political opposition as illegitimate, the loss of press freedom or political and media coordination toward anti-democratic ends, elites eschewing norms that protect democratic processes and institutions, and, broadly, the erosion of mechanisms of accountability over political elites. Media and information, disinformation, and propaganda absolutely play roles in many of these processes, even if they might not be their primary drivers. That fact alone makes misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda a central problem for contemporary states. And, while none of these things originated with the Internet or social media, they afford potentially harmful communications at a scale unprecedented in global history.

10.2 Definitions and Delineations

First, we need some definitions of the important things discussed in this chapter. *Polarization* refers to the distance between groups on any one of a number of measures (Iyengar et al. 2019). This can span the different political views groups hold, the social groups people perceive themselves identifying with, the moral values groups possess, and the feelings that groups have toward one another. Scholars roughly distinguish between *ideological polarization* (the distance between groups in terms of their policy preferences), *affective polarization* (the extent to which supporters of one group dislike the other group), and *social polarization* (the distance that social groups perceive themselves to be from one another) (Tucker et al. 2018).

Disinformation refers to false or misleading information that is produced with the intent to deceive, whereas *misinformation* is factually false, but lacks this intent (Freelon & Wells 2020). This means that disinformation is a subset of misinformation in being false information *plus* the intent to deceive (Vraga & Bode 2020). Disinformation, we shall soon see, is often a tool wielded in the pursuit of political power. *Malinformation* is a term that researchers use to capture information that combines truth and untruth, and/or strips context away from information, or is harmful and not necessarily false, all with the intent to deceive (Keller et al. 2020). *Propaganda* is related to all of these things, and generally refers to longer-term *campaigns* combining many different types of information which are designed to manipulate some target population (Reddi et al. 2021). It is important to understand that propaganda is more than just a piece of disinformation; it usually is used in contexts where the intent is to mislead, disrupt, or rally public support in a target population for strategic gain. Propaganda may even be “potentially factually correct information, but packaged in a way so as to disparage opposing viewpoints” (Tucker et al. 2018: 3).

As a shorthand, throughout this chapter we refer to “misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda” as MDP when we are discussing them together. Since 2016, there has been an explosion of research on all of these things, from the role of misinformation in shaping health outcomes and disinformation during the attempted coup of January 6, 2021 in the US, to the ways in which propaganda often works to racially polarize countries (Reddi et al. 2021). While it has new salience, MDP is an old concern. As the great American sociologist W. E. B. Du Bois (2014) wrote nearly a century ago, propaganda by historians helped to justify and legitimate continued racial inequalities in the US in the post-Civil War era. During World War II, the systematic development and dissemination of propaganda became a well-established tool of states challenging one another for the hearts and minds of people around the world (Tworek 2019). Nazi propaganda on radio in Germany legitimized the Shoah, the genocide of European Jews during World War II, and mobilized public support for the World War. Propaganda during the Cold War helped create the Manichean worldview of two opposing and irreconcilable systems (e.g. Rawnsley 2016), and was a key way the US and Russia worked to undermine governments in accordance with their strategic interests.

Other scholars have charted what is new in our era, especially the enormous reach and scale of mis- and disinformation on social media, including how platforms have enabled those with extreme views to find one another, make common cause, and take collective and connective action (Hart 2021). Others have analyzed the degree to which misinformation and disinformation leads people to have skewed understandings of everything from the efficacy of Covid-19 vaccines to the policy positions of political opponents or the integrity of elections (Kernell & Mullinix 2019; Tenove 2020). Still others take up the question of combating MDP – detailing necessary investments in fact-checking, quality journalism, local news, and civic literacy; tougher platform policies that root out harmful content; and government regulation to provide oversight for these commercial entities (e.g. Southwell et al. 2018).

10.3 The Dynamics of Platforms, Information, and Political Identity

Over the past ten years, scholars in many different countries have come to more fully appreciate the role of *identity* in politics (Sides et al. 2019). By “identity,” we fundamentally mean difference – the understandings of the self and its relation to others premised on a set of distinctions that people make (Ellemers & Haslam 2012). Identities are the products of socialization and agency, the sense of ourselves we take on as we make our way in the world. Often, the most important social identities are those formed through socialization after birth. We are all born into families or relationships that tell us who we are as people – which people are the same as, similar to, or different from us (Eveland & Nathanson 2020). Individuals come to see themselves – through explicit teaching and being in the world – as a part of various social groups and, crucially, not a part of others. These most obviously include family and primary relationship units, but also geographic communities, and groups based on religion, class, sexuality and gender identity, race and ethnicity, class, etc.

It is clear that identities are a product of the stories we create for ourselves and those that are created for us and circulate in the world. People ascribe identities to other people and treat them on that basis. Think about all the ways groups relate visual markers for things such as race and class to people and treat them differently accordingly. And, sometimes, identities are structural in the sense that they are enshrined in law. Think, for instance, about countries with long histories of colonial occupation or racial discrimination that have formal legal definitions of various groups. Or think about identities that relate to citizenship status, or lack thereof. Sometimes, social identities are deeply rooted in history and culture in ways that provide the backdrop for that socialization process – people with shared multigenerational histories and stories of belonging and group status, for instance, such as religious communities. Sometimes, identities are received in the sense of things that are passed on within families without much thought, and sometimes they color everyday life and activities through explicit teaching – both of which can characterize partisanship and party member identities. Sometimes, identities are things that we come to recognize or embrace about ourselves, such as our sexuality and gender identities. And, sometimes, identities are more voluntaristic and expressive, such as sports fandom or musical taste groups.

Social scientists have long noted how identities provide a sense of belonging, place in the world, frame of reference, and set of stories that help make sense of life. What is important for our purposes are the ways that all sorts of identities can be made *political* through communication (Jardina 2019). An important part of what politicians and political leaders do is tell stories of identity – who is a part of groups and who is not, which groups are legitimate, which groups should lead, which groups have power and should have power, which groups compose a nation and which should, and what histories and struggles and triumphs groups of people share (Kreiss et al. 2020). In all countries, there are old and well-established “stories of peoplehood” (Smith 2003) that shape politics and political identity. These often relate to race and ethnicity, religion, and class, explicitly or implicitly, and they must be continually renewed and reinvested with political meaning so they stay salient as political identities. Media are central to identity as key sites for the creation and circulation of these stories of identification and belonging (Kreiss 2016; Peck 2019).

As for the power of identity, take, for instance, the idea of belonging to a specific “nation” – something that today is very close to the identity of many people, not only nationalists. People centrally identify as Americans, Italians, Germans, Panamanians, or New Zealanders. In nearly every country around the world, national belonging is a central identity (see Kohn & Calhoun 2017). However, the idea of nations is not very old, and most of the nations we know today did not exist before the nineteenth century. Until 1871, “Germany” was a patchwork of dozens of small dukedoms or kingdoms, and only exists in its current form since 1989. “Italy” only came into being in 1861 after a war of independence, and still many citizens identify as Tuscans or Venetians rather than Italians. Most African countries have borders that were artificially drawn by colonial powers in London or Paris, eventually leading to horrible wars between peoples who found themselves in “nations” that cut across their identities, territories, and allegiances. This means that a lot of cultural work had to go into solidifying the nation as an identity, suffused with perceptions of groups that are legitimately part of it. This work includes visual symbols (such as flags), myths (such as those of founding and battle), monuments and architecture (the design of state buildings and symbols asserted in public space), and stories told by political and social elites over time. Indeed, the most enduring stories are written in monuments and memorials, inscribed in stone and architecture, erected to ensure collective memory across generations (Edy 2006).

National identity is uniquely powerful, salient, and enduring. Other identities can be more hastily and temporally activated – such as when politicians make appeals to groups by adopting specific policy stances during the course of an election for electoral gain. Sometimes, identities are inherently political, although they can have strong lifestyle components as well – think about the environmental movement and green parties around the world. Sometimes, non-political identities can become political if groups perceive themselves to be under threat or work to advance their interests vis-à-vis other groups. At the same time, none of us is a member of just one group – we all carry multiple identities with us all the time (Hogg & Reid 2006): we are members of political parties, religious and geographic communities, have racial and ethnic identities, gender identities, etc. Social scientists refer to these as “cross-cutting” (Mason 2016) identities when they cross lines of social division.

Over the past few years, however, scholars have grown increasingly concerned with the ways partisanship in many countries becomes a mega-identity that subsumes many other social identities – a process that the political scientist Liliana Mason (2016) calls “sorting” in her studies of the US context. For example, in the paradigmatic case of the US, Democrats and Republicans are not just members of political parties, they are often members of increasingly cohesive, different social groups. Democrats are more multiracial and ethnic, tend to live more in urban areas, be more secular, and have lower class status on average. Republicans are generally white, populate more rural areas, are more religious, and tend to be wealthier.

None of these things applies to *all* Democrats or Republicans, of course – they are true on average. But one consistent finding is the increasing decline in cross-cutting identities as political parties become more homogeneously sorted, especially on racial and ethnic lines, which democracy scholars tell us raises the stakes of politics to be about not just winning an election, but preserving a way of life (Haggard & Kaufman 2021). The US is not alone, although these issues are exacerbated by a two-party, winner-take-all system. In many countries, for instance, social differences are increasingly being sorted into political causes

and parties – and media are central to these processes (Walter 2022). As scholars have shown about the United Kingdom European Union membership referendum, and about tensions across Europe more broadly, racial, ethnic, and religious differences are increasingly the lines of political division (Caller & Gorodzeisky 2022; Sobolewska & Ford 2020).

Polarization occurs when groups, on any number of dimensions, come to perceive themselves as far apart, and view different groups more negatively (Wilson et al. 2020). As detailed above, ideological polarization refers to differences in political beliefs, for example regarding policies. Affective polarization refers to negative feelings about different groups (M. Wagner 2021; Wojcieszak & Garrett 2018). Social polarization (Goodman et al. 2022) refers to the perceived differences between groups of people. Moral polarization refers to different orientations groups have, in terms of values and beliefs about right and wrong (Tappin & McKay 2019). Sometimes, polarization is based on underlying structures, such as differences in race, ethnicity, and class in terms of wealth, access to political power, and health outcomes (Hooker 2009). Sometimes, polarization is more of a matter of perception or, more accurately, misperception, where we mischaracterize the other side (Garrett et al. 2019).

And, sometimes, polarization is the result of the *accurate* perception of the other side amid political and social conflict (Kreiss & McGregor 2022). Sometimes, polarization is rooted fundamentally in interest – the desire of groups to maintain, enhance, or achieve power. This brings up an important point because, whereas many researchers decry polarization itself, often they might be witnessing something far more disruptive to democracy – inequality. Indeed, challenges to inequality are often deeply polarizing because some groups are attempting to achieve equality while others are holding on to their power (Hooker 2009, 2016). The democratic threat here is not polarization, but the defense of inequality in the face of attempts at redress.

This brings us to an important insight. Much work on democracy and technology – or, more narrowly, polarization and technology – leads with looking at technological causes of our present democratic and social crises – with mixed results (Kubin & von Sikorski 2021; Tucker et al. 2018). In some ways, this makes sense. Media are often most visible to us, much more so than political or social structures. And because technology changes, people often assume that media and technology are driving other changes that we also perceive and see around us, such as growing acrimony in political debate or hardening lines of social division.

Indeed, while in the past decade there has been growing concern over things such as mis- and disinformation, which we turn to in greater detail below – especially the capacity of these things to skew the public's decision-making capacities during elections or understandings of public health – if identity is the real locus of politics, these things are less of a concern. For instance, in recent years, scholars have paid renewed attention to identity appeals in political communication – those attempts by political elites to craft salient political identities, appeal to these groups, claim to credibly represent them, mobilize them for electoral gain, and ultimately win power. In this world, it might be less important whether a citizen has limited knowledge of politics, or even holds correct views on policy or other matters; what matters is that they can perceive who will credibly represent their group interests.

Finally, we also have to be careful here about being overly concerned with polarization. Sometimes politics is not just about winning elections, but about achieving or protecting political equality, even as it can often be quite literally about preserving ways of life and social status. Polarization often stems from very real political conflicts between social groups over political, economic, cultural, and social power. And political elites and leaders in many different domains of social life often utilize communication and wield media to create lines of political and social difference in the course of pursuing political power for the interests they represent. Of course, they often do so while also affirming the institutional rules and broader civic commitments (such as honoring the results of elections) that lie underneath contests with political adversaries, but fundamentally politics is about creating, and mobilizing across, lines of difference. In the end, before we adopt any blanket concerns about polarization, we must evaluate the political and social status of various groups contesting power, and prioritize remedying inequality over social division.

10.4 Mis- and Disinformation and Propaganda (MDP)

Imagine a river. It is well established, always flowing, cutting deep grooves into the earth. When it rains, water flows from millions of smaller channels into the river, flowing downhill over mountains, hills, and grasslands and finding their way into the main channel.

Rivers provide an apt metaphor for misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda. As a reminder, misinformation generally refers to content that is false, but not propagated with the intent to deceive, while disinformation is deliberately crafted to deceive. Propaganda is a more expansive category of content that is intended to deceive or, more often, manipulate, and unfolds over time through *many* different messages and forms of communication. The content of propaganda *campaigns* might mix truth and falsehoods, half-truths, hyperbole, and other statements. But the content of propaganda is often not wholly made up; instead, it repurposes bits from established cultures and symbols, and often flows in deep, well-established currents alongside other ideas that are powerful.

There are a couple of different ways to think about misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda (MDP). Some questions include: Who or what groups are behind MDP, and what interests do they have? What are its dynamics, such as how does it spread, and why? And what are the consequences of mis- and disinformation and propaganda?

MDP as a Concern

MDP is not new. MDP has been a significant concern among researchers, governments, reformers, and civil society actors for a very, very long time, although we have not always used the same terms in public discourse. As Rachel Kuo and Alice Marwick (2021) point out in their historicization of MDP, we can think about campaigns in the US against immigrants and stories about “welfare queens” as examples of disinformation and propaganda – all during an earlier, mass-mediated era. Researchers and theorists have been writing about the roles of gossip, rumors, scandal, fabrications of political fact, campaigns to strategically undermine the standing of some political elites or public figures, among many other related things, in countries around the world since the 1800s, when a broader concern with the knowledge of the public first emerged (publics that were at the time deeply exclusionary on the lines of race, gender, and class).

Indeed, the relationship between information and public attitudes is a distinctly modern problem, dating roughly since the rise of public opinion as an independent force checking the king's sovereignty in the 1600s. Public debate about information and public opinion expanded considerably with the rise of popular sovereignty over the ensuing three centuries (although it took well into the twentieth century for the boundaries of the public to be extended to racial and ethnic minorities and women in many countries). Concern over the public's capacity to participate in politics was deeply rooted in democracies such as the United States, France, and the UK as debates over suffrage expanded – concerns that were often inflected with elite judgments and pretensions, and especially targeted at poorer groups and racial and ethnic minorities.

Today, researchers the world over have primarily focused on how MDP undermines the information and knowledge that citizens have, and, as such, see it as a significant threat to democracy. Because of MDP, individuals make less informed choices at the polls when choosing between candidates to represent them, or when they vote on specific issues through referendums. Secondly, MDP distorts the shape of public opinion itself, either skewing it (in the case of misinformation) or distorting it strategically (in the case of disinformation and propaganda). The result is that politicians might have different incentives, or might respond differently, when faced with a skewed or misled public opinion that looks very different than if the public were ideally informed. Moreover, politicians might be able to avoid accountability at the ballot box or from other powerful institutions if public opinion is undermined (especially a concern with disinformation campaigns).

Another rather new aspect of MDP is what Yochai Benkler and colleagues (2018) have termed *network propaganda*. In part unique to the era of digital platforms, network propaganda does not emanate from one identifiable source – such as when a radio station or website is known as a propaganda channel, e.g. Russia Today. Instead, nearly identical propaganda messages come from multiple sources, or cross-reference and build onto one another, washed into citizen's social media feeds, chats, and search results from various directions (see Lukito 2020; Marwick 2018; Tripodi 2022). In this way, new networks of strategic, duplicitous actors on social media platforms can disguise propaganda as authentic, organic content from trusted contacts, even cloaking it as some sort of grassroots knowledge. The key lies in “discrete sources and narrative bits” (Benkler et al. 2016: 8) – propaganda messages are spread in various versions by multiple outlets, with the effect of “adding credibility and improving recall of the false, misleading or otherwise manipulative narrative in the target population” (2016: 8). Sometimes, these propaganda actors are domestic sources; at other times, they are foreign agents, and especially states, for example inauthentic networks from Iran meddling with US elections (K. Wagner 2021), Russian media such as Russia Today spreading anti-vaccine disinformation in Germany (Scott 2021), or religious groups in the US interfering with an abortion referendum in Ireland (O’Leary 2018).

Similar, but different, are the many new forms of *computational propaganda* that platforms afford and enable (Woolley & Howard 2017). The term “computational propaganda” is used to describe the phenomenon of intentionally spreading disinformation and attempting to manipulate public opinion through social media networks by making use of automation and digital tools such as social bots (Woolley & Howard 2018). Algorithms can deceive, and automated accounts (so-called “social bots”) can multiply messages on a large scale. Numerous studies from various countries employing a broad methodological toolset have

shown that social bots have been active in election campaigns in the past years (e.g. Bastos & Mercea 2019; Boichak et al. 2021; Ferrara 2017; Keller & Klinger 2018). And the effects of computational propaganda are rarely evenly distributed. Women and candidates from minority groups in particular face hate campaigns, harassment, and uncivil behavior on social media and comment sections of news portals, including from automated accounts, which may discourage these groups from participating in electoral contests and silence diverse voices (Beltran et al. 2021; Kenski et al. 2020; Krook & Sanín 2020; Rheault et al. 2019).

Computational propaganda may impact election campaigns in various ways – distorting the perceptions of the opinion climate (Matthes & Arendt 2016), silencing minority groups, or artificially amplifying fringe actors or opinions. Researchers applying agent-based modeling have even concluded that, in some settings, networks made up of 2–4 percent bots would be sufficient to turn the opinion climate and easily “sway public opinion – or the expression thereof.” This effect has also been found in real Twitter networks, which the company calls “malicious automation” in its quarterly transparency reports. Morales (2019) showed that, after Twitter had deleted more than 6,000 automated accounts that retweeted Venezuela’s then-President Maduro in 2013, users’ willingness to express criticism of the president, as well as support for the opposition, significantly increased. These bot accounts represented less than 0.5 percent of Maduro’s followers, but the president’s retweets dropped by 81 percent after their suspension.

The detection of bots is tedious and anything but an exact science – with limited data access to platforms, and tools and methods based on very different premises and definitions of “bots,” scholars can only approximate how many bots there are (Martini et al. 2021; Schuchard & Crooks 2021). As a consequence, scholars have not yet found a way to prove (or disprove) the effects bots have (or don’t have) on public discourse or election campaigns. Also, small numbers of superspreaders and superusers benefit from network effects and can have an overblown impact on online discourse and information flows – whether these accounts are automated, partially automated, or authentic. It is possible that hyperactive users or active, strategic groups coordinate their social media accounts, including automated ones, to have similar patterns in attempts to strategically manipulate public opinion.

Quandt (2018) argues that the idea of “dark participation” captures various forms of technology-enabled malign participation, which has surged with the rise of platforms. It includes various new actors (social bots, trolls, and inauthentic networks) and strategies (amplifying loud minorities, mass-reporting of accounts in order to take them down, and hijacking hashtags). Major platforms have sought to address some of these things, and report about their efforts to delete accounts and content in their transparency reports. For instance, in 2021, Twitter announced a new team to label social bots, with the aim of signaling malign automation while keeping “fun” bots on the platform (including introducing a “good bots label” [Twitter Safety 2021]). In a similar way, regulators around the world have started to recognize the disruptive potential of automated communication on platforms, and some have introduced an obligation for platforms to label social bots (e.g. in California and Germany). Even so, many smaller platforms struggle to develop countermeasures and, even when platforms take action, their measures often remain opaque, unverifiable, and irreplicable.

Bots and fake and spam accounts are not all there is. Photos or videos can be changed and faked with the intent to deceive. “Deep fakes” – seemingly realistic videos based on

artificial intelligence that display somebody saying and doing things that are fake, through video and/or sound synthesis techniques – are still more a potential threat than a widespread reality, but provide a glimpse into what might soon be possible (Vaccari & Chadwick 2020). This is a technology that can put words into the mouth of literally anyone, creating false video and sound bites (in one instance, for example, of former US President Obama in one instance [Silverman 2018]). The manipulative danger posed by deep fakes has to do with two elements in particular: they potentially lend greater credibility to disinformation, and the technology is accessible even to laypeople.

All of these things, as well as MDP more broadly, potentially lead to a spiraling dynamic of less media and institutional trust. Deep fakes reinforce the epistemic crisis that has already gained momentum from the flood of disinformation during the Covid-19 pandemic. It is easier, when compared with the mass media era, to fashion alternative and conspiracy narratives and realities and make them plausible, as well as to delegitimize facts and scientifically sound knowledge. In relation to election campaigns, for instance, it can indeed have extremely disruptive effects if manipulated videos of politicians circulate. Diakopoulos and Johnson (2021) outline a few of them: deception and intimidation of viewers/listeners, reputation damages and harms to those misrepresented, and a broad undermining of trust in social institutions.

That said, the existing empirical evidence that MDP leads to less trust is not as straightforward (Valenzuela et al. 2022). Indeed, these concerns might be mitigated by the fact that much research suggests that there are other important considerations about public opinion we must account for. First, that the public – even at the best of times – is often ill informed, disinterested, not attentive, and ideologically incoherent when it comes to policy positions. Second, that a long, long line of research suggests that political elites are actually the ones who shape public attitudes, not the other way round. Third, that political elites may take their cues *less* from public opinion, and more from interest groups represented in their party coalitions.

That said, it is also clear that misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda have consequences, even if they might be rooted in deeper causes such as striving for political gain or financial profit.

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

As we have seen in countries from the United States to Brazil, mis- and disinformation about Covid-19 and the efficacy of vaccines have cost thousands of lives, prolonged the global pandemic, and resulted in more severe and deadly illness for millions around the world. In countries such as India and Ethiopia, misinformation, disinformation, and propaganda about minority racial and ethnic groups have resulted in systemic violence and attacks. While this symbolic violence often emerges from political interest, the types of toxic information circulated on platforms have exacerbated conflict and furthered the power of the individuals and groups behind it. This has opened an important debate globally over the harms that platforms potentially cause, and the approaches to internal and external regulation that might mitigate these harms.

10.5 How MDP Works

In 2018, a party in the opposition won a general election in Malaysia for the first time since independence in 1957. The previous party in power was made up of the political elite of ethnic and Islamic Malays, which held on to power in part through the creation and fostering of social difference and grievances along the lines of racial and religious conflict, which in turn provided the context for extremism and disinformation. In this context, MDP is both reflective of broader political struggles and structures of meaning, and a tool used by elites to manipulate and divide populations in the context of wider political and cultural conflict (Radue 2019). This raises a key point. While we often imagine MDP in terms of discrete bits of information that are false, deceptive, or misleading, information often only makes sense when fit within larger frameworks or structures of meaning. In other words, instead of focusing narrowly on the content of discrete pieces of information, think about the social and cultural structures that MDP is produced and embedded within. Often, MDP reveals worldviews that are required to make sense of it – and those worldviews come embedded with understandings of how the world *should* be, to which MDP appeals. At the root of all of these things is power – political, social, and economic, and the relative status of groups.

To provide a few examples: MDP often targets people with less power, or serves to enhance the power of those who already have it. In 2017, the Myanmar military took violent action against the country's Muslim minority: the Rohingya people. In the years leading up to it, Facebook was a site for the amplification of hate speech and violent incitement that helped lay the groundwork for ethnic cleansing. While hate speech – against the Rohingya, as against other minority groups, such as during the civil conflict in Ethiopia that also resulted in ethnic violence (Akinwotu 2021) – rarely originates on social media, platforms can become the key sites for the dissemination of well-established social and political discourses that marginalize people and justify violent actions.

The reality is that MDP is often a tool of political power wielded and deployed *against* those in marginalized positions with respect to race, ethnicity, gender, religion, or class. Sometimes, this means MDP directed at vulnerable people is designed to weaken their political position or keep them from doing things such as voting, or having a voice in public. Sometimes, MDP is directed toward a dominant group to amplify tensions with vulnerable groups. As such, MDP is not exclusively directed at vulnerable populations – if you think of international disinformation against vaccines, for instance, it moved seamlessly across class and racial and ethnic lines. However, the impacts of MDP on social groups are different. The consequences of being unvaccinated and having great healthcare, for instance, are often significantly less than if you are unvaccinated and have no healthcare access. At the same time, even something such as MDP directed against Covid-19 vaccines still accords with political interest (i.e., limiting the power of the state to regulate aspects of society, long a right-wing goal and the aim of numerous disinformation campaigns, including undermining the science around smoking and climate change).

Indeed, MDP often works to create doubt. Scholars have long pointed to the fact that ignorance is often not a *lack* of something: it is actively *produced*. Classic work in the sociology of science (Oreskes & Conway 2010), for instance, showed that, in cases from the safety of cigarette smoking to climate change, those seeking to undermine scientific consensus and policymakers' and the public's understanding of it sought to cultivate *doubt*. If we doubt the facts, for instance, there is less need to actually take actions to address

public health or the melting of the icebergs. Relatedly, political scientists have shown how governments do not produce data and information on things they do not want to identify as public problems (Jones & Baumgartner 2005) – including gun violence in the US.

In other words, what MDP often does is create the conditions for people to doubt what is true, which in turn proves handy at staving off regulation (such as policy interventions) or content moderation by platforms. The most sophisticated purveyors of MDP will often not advance expressly false claims, but create doubt through the guise of asking an endless array of questions designed to undermine knowledge claims – from the efficacy of vaccines against Covid-19 to the reliability of an electoral vote count. Often, creating doubt works to undermine knowledge-producing institutions *and* the legitimacy of public action. More broadly, the cultivation of doubt can work to undermine *all* knowledge-producing institutions and a general sense of what is true among the public.

MDP often comes from the top. In summer 2021, in the face of disastrous losses from Covid-19, a state headed by India’s ruling Bharatiya Janata Party began distributing herbal remedies for sick patients (Badrinathan 2021). Meanwhile, former Brazilian President Jair Bolsonaro emerged as the global leader of a “coronavirus-denial movement” (Ricard & Medeiros 2020). What these stories have in common is that MDP often originates from political elites, actors, and interests – and even when it does not, it is aided in its spread and credibility by the elites who embrace it. They are also likely the most persuasive actors. We have decades of political science research, for instance, that tells us that what elites say and do – on matters of policy and identity (as prototypes of what groups believe and consist of) – has particular influence on public opinions and attitudes. The upshot is that people – with limited time, effort, and interest – take their cues from elites as to what to believe and who to identify with – and that includes MDP.

SPOTLIGHTED CASE

In 2022, a group of Canadian truckers and activists calling themselves the “Freedom Convoy” shut down the city center in Ottawa, Canada, in protest against Covid-19 health measures, including mandated vaccinations. The protest quickly became a cause célèbre internationally, especially on the right in the United States, where Fox News and opinion shows such as Tucker Carlson’s embraced and promoted it. However, not even the trucker’s own labor union supported the protests, and over 90 percent of Canada’s truckers were already vaccinated and not even affected by the new health measures. It turns out that the protest was fueled, in part, by a Bangladeshi marketing firm and right-wing political and media interests seeking to advance a narrative to undermine governmental authority.

MDP also flows across international boundaries and includes groups with very different motivations. The Canadian “Freedom Convoy” mentioned in the box was embraced not just by Fox News, but also apparently by a shadowy network of fraudulent Facebook groups that helped promote and fundraise for the protests (Reilly et al. 2022). Groups such as QAnon and international white supremacist groups were also involved in these protests. All of this reveals how MDP flows across international boundaries, and often involves people and groups with many disparate, but overlapping, interests: from the truckers engaging in protest, political entertainers looking to build audience share for ideological

programs, marketers using social media, and conspiracy movements and political groups looking to recruit new members and advance right-wing projects.

Indeed, MDP is often reflective of political interests. As suggested above, even if misinformation does not originate with elites, organized interests will often harness it for their political ends. Take the example of vaccines. While there have long been anti-vaccine movements and sentiments, pre-Covid-19 they generally crossed the ideological spectrum in many countries around the world. During Covid-19, however, right-wing movements worldwide found that seizing on opposition to vaccines – and Covid-19 public health restrictions more generally, like the lockdowns and mask mandates which we saw in countries such as the United States, Canada, Germany, France, Sweden, Brazil, and India – could be framed in terms of religious purity and liberty and used for political gain on the right (Amin et al. 2017). Indeed, MDP often articulates a set of stories about the world that are mobilizational, and can infuse political institutions and movements with new life.

As such, MDP is often driven by concentrations of people with disparate aims and interests, and spreads through various means. As discussed above, studies suggest that, in the context of certain forms of misinformation, it is often a highly concentrated network phenomenon, where a small group of people are “superusers” responsible for the *vast* amount of the MDP that receives widespread circulation (Hindman et al. 2022). Studies have routinely found that a small number of people, sometimes working in concert and coordination, have been responsible for MDP across particular domains (e.g. González Bailón & Wang 2016; Klinger et al. 2022b; Papakyriakopoulos et al. 2019). This makes sense given what we know about the Internet – attention is not distributed evenly, but in ways that are highly stratified. Network effects mean those already with large followings (or those who port other forms of capital to the Internet) command significant attention. The influence of users is often the result of their ability to employ abusive, highly emotional, or controversial language that drives the engagement that platforms design for, given their commercial motivations. While elites and superusers are often responsible for originating MDP, it is frequently spread by those with a diverse set of attitudes and interests. People interact and engage with MDP to signal their social identities and political affiliations (Marwick & Hargittai 2019; Polletta & Callahan 2019); based on their trust in the source and understandings of recipients (Buchanan & Benson 2019); and for their own interests, including politics (Bennett & Livingston 2018) or even perceived altruism (Apuke & Omar 2021).

SPOTLIGHTED CONTENT

MDP is also a hybrid-media phenomenon. As the Canadian “Freedom Convoy” example cited above shows, MDP is often the product of the dynamics between movements and elites, playing out across many different media and platforms. While much public discourse and regulatory conversations the world over have narrowly focused on technology platforms such as Meta and Google Search, MDP does not respect arbitrary boundaries between media. The content of mass media such as newspapers and websites spills onto platforms, where people engage with and share it. The products of talk radio and podcasts in countries around the world make their way to WhatsApp and, with enough engagement, to national media outlets that command huge audiences.

Indeed, a tactic of media manipulators is often to seed and launder MDP across many media outlets horizontally and vertically – what scholars call “trading up the chain” (Krafft & Donovan 2020), moving content to more high-profile outlets where it can command much larger audiences. And what is articulated online often makes its way offline, as a study of the 2018 Zimbabwean national elections reveals (Chibwe 2020).

MDP can also be weaponized by states and other political actors. It is, perhaps, the canonical example that MDP is a tool of states conducting information warfare. On the one hand, states such as Russia have used MDP in countries around the world to derive political advantage (Hellman & Wagnsson 2017). This is an old tactic, of course. Since World Wars I and II, and the long Cold War, states have long deployed propaganda and information tactics to shape public opinion in their favor. Meanwhile, as researchers have documented, given the outsized concern over MDP, it did not take long for claims of disinformation to become a potent political weapon. States have wielded claims of disinformation to support the political regulation of social media. Parties have sought to deploy the rhetoric of MDP against opponents. In this context, claims of concern over MDP themselves can be anti-democratic, limiting the political opposition and expression directed against the powerful.

Finally, a focus on MDP can serve to mask the political dynamics at play. There simply is no empirical evidence that the attempted coup on January 6, 2021 in the

United States took place because people were genuinely confused about the outcome of the election. Some people surely were. Many people surely were not. There is often a challenge in surveying people who have been exposed to MDP (it is not easy to find them, people are notoriously bad about recalling what they have seen and heard, and it is often difficult to be sure people are answering honestly versus in accordance with their self-interest). Moreover, we do not know why people answer surveys the way that they do. When Republicans in the United States say they believe that Trump won the election, are they saying this because they genuinely believe it? Or because they know it is what a Republican is supposed to say? Or because it fits with their political and social interests to believe as much? The reality is that empirical evidence is often murky about the consequences and effects of even the most visible cases of disinformation. In that light, we should not immediately look to MDP as a *cause* over and above other explanations, such as social identity, political and social interests, social status, and political power – which

likely play a greater role in motivating events like those on January 6, 2021 (Feuer et al. 2022).

10.6 Public Knowledge, Information, and Democracy

Since the eighteenth century, many Western societies have tightly coupled an emphasis on the knowledge and fact basis of public reason and collective rationality with democracy, governance, and social cohesion. Central to this has been the idea that public opinion, democratic legitimacy, and democratic outcomes depend on a rational, and deliberating, public. Through the reasoned give and take of arguments, the public – and presumably its political leaders – will realize consensus, make good decisions, or, at the very least, make decisions that have democratic legitimacy. In accordance with this, over the past three centuries, many societies have developed various knowledge-producing institutions that serve governance and informed public opinion – in addition to informed *elite* opinion (i.e., those policymakers and regulatory offices that do the work of crafting legislation). Think about government survey offices, bureaus that produce economic statistics, and public health agencies, on one level. On another, universities that house, foster, and cultivate knowledge over long periods of time in accordance with the institutions of science and social science, premised on peer review systems to vet knowledge claims, serve a similar role. On still another is the international journalism that – while looking different in different countries and continually changing within countries – generally developed in many countries around the world as a structured, institutionalized way of: (1) producing current information about public and political life; (2) representing and mobilizing a range of political opinions in pluralistic societies; (3) holding elites accountable through communicative scrutiny and representations of public opinion; and (4) defining public standards of morality and ethics so violations of them became matters of public concern.

Over the past two decades, in many countries, trust in these institutions has been under considerable assault from a variety of pressures. The first is from political elites themselves, who in many locations have found political gain in attacking the press and other knowledge-producing institutions. They have done so variously to appeal to groups in the electorate, undermine their accountability both at the ballot box and in public opinion, pursue their agendas, and shape the contextual environment of public opinion and information to their long-term advantage. The second is the rapid expansion in many countries, over 40 years, of new and different types of communicative media, and especially the Internet. This has meant the explosion of ideological, interest, and (hyper)partisan media in many countries, from community and talk radio to partisan and identity-based publications that have found cheaper printing and distribution. Meanwhile, with the Internet and social media, it became possible for a much wider array of individuals to communicate at scale than in previous eras. This has fueled both an incredible array of political information and opinion, *and* new kinds of noxious, racist, and false information. It has also contributed to the addition into the public sphere of new voices that were closed off from addressing large audiences during the era of capital-intensive mass communications media – including racial and ethnic minority (Jackson 2022), trans- (Billard 2019), gender, and class groups (Jackson et al. 2020). Indeed, as a historical matter, public spheres in Western democracies have long been premised on colonial and racial projects that created the resource bases for European empires and exclusions of non-whites, women, and non-elite classes from addressing publics.

Indeed, and finally, we must note the global dynamics of inequality and citizenship that lie in the background of many political conflicts and make any simple story of “trust” deeply complicated and contested. While there have always been deeply stratified classes in many societies, since the advent of the “information age” – in which knowledge and technical systems increasingly structure many global economies – inequality has been on the rise. At the same time, the twentieth century witnessed many decolonization movements and postcolonial politics that featured struggles for political equality and civic incorporation – the basic granting of citizenship privileges and rights for formerly disenfranchised racial and ethnic minorities. In many countries, over the last century and a half, racial and ethnic minorities have challenged dominant groups over political and economic status.

Often, trust in knowledge-producing institutions plays out against these larger forces. Even though it is often valorized now, international journalism – as generations of scholars such as the Jamaican-born British academic Stuart Hall have demonstrated, for instance – often represents elite institutions, privileges existing systems, generally defends the status quo, and promotes established institutional orders – however unequal they might be. As noted above, W. E. B. Du Bois noted in the 1930s that academic knowledge itself was directed toward upholding unequal racial social orders. More contemporaneously, scholars of public health have long noted pervasive economic and racial and ethnic inequalities in the creation of health knowledge and outcomes, including deeply systematic ways that non-elites have been the subject of scientific knowledge that has devalued them (think about the global HIV/AIDS crisis, for instance, which was the focus of an international movement to challenge the structures of science that initially ignored and devalued the disease, and condemned its victims). Even when science is conscious of biases, interventions often follow economic and social disparities in structuring outcomes.

Against this backdrop, it is legitimate to ask how much trust individuals *should* have in knowledge-producing institutions. For platforms, the question of trust is multi-faceted – what sorts of information should platforms privilege, and why? What sorts of information should they reject in all its forms, and why? What institutions should they elevate and amplify? Why should people trust platforms to make these decisions over and above elected representatives or those who claim to serve public, not commercial, interests? Is the market mechanism of platforms sufficient to ensure their legitimacy and responsiveness to the public? Is the market mechanism of much journalism sufficient to secure its obligation to the public trust? In general, where should lines be drawn between expressive liberty and democratic harm – and should this be contingent on time, given that what we think we know is true at time A is rarely the same as at time B? And is there one line, or many potential lines, to be drawn in pluralistic public spheres?

The challenge, going forward, is to clearly identify how societies can balance the democratic potential of platforms with their harms. On the one hand, the democratic potential of social media is evident in the power and scale of global movements such as Black Lives Matter or Fridays for Future. On the other hand are the global flows of conspiracy movements such as QAnon and misinformation, fueled organically by millions of individuals around the world sharing their political opinions and (mis) understandings of facts, and often directed against those who lack social and economic power. We also need to account for what is disinformation and propaganda in the service of political interests – such as upholding unequal social orders, status, and power in democracies – versus what is solely an information problem. Indeed, of much bigger potential concern are the ways in which information gets wielded as a strategic political tool, one used to undermine

accountability or otherwise expand political power. And, as detailed above, understanding how MDP accords with deeprooted, well-worn grooves in culture – the things we are already organized to think and believe – makes it clear that our concerns are often only about the outwardly most evident and surface-level information.

10.7 What Should Be Our Response to MDP

So what do platforms, policymakers, civil society activists, and publics do about MDP? Individually, we all have an obligation to be cognizant and aware of the information we encounter and what we choose to place our trust in. A number of scholars have written about the problem of MDP through the lens of a public health crisis and the metaphor is a good one (Jamieson 2021). In a public health crisis, individuals are called upon to take actions that protect other individuals, especially the most vulnerable, even if it means sacrificing some of their own freedom. Think of Covid-19 masking, testing, social distancing, and getting vaccinated as measures not only to protect individuals, but as acknowledging people's responsibilities to others.

For individuals, vetting information and checking sources, taking a step back and refusing to engage with emotionally charged content if it undermines other people's dignity or equality, not sharing things that are problematic or racist, not sharing content before actually reading it beyond the clickbait headline and teaser, supporting family members and friends, trying to do outreach to those under the thrall of MDP, being an ally to those most vulnerable, and supporting trustworthy information producers are things that everyone can do. In addition, people can embrace a general ethical commitment to institutionally reliable, verifiable, or personally witnessed facts at the foundation of public debate – but also have the humility to acknowledge when we hit the limits of our understanding.

At the same time, just as the response to Covid-19 could not be wholly individual, nor can the response to our contemporary challenges with MDP. Individual actions only take us so far – think about the development of vaccines and their global distribution, the manufacture of masks, and the vast array of scientific research that was necessary to determine the causes, threats, and dangers of Covid-19. Wearing masks and getting vaccinated were individual responsibilities, but individuals could not produce vaccines alone, and neither can they combat MDP on their own. To do that, we need a strong collective response through our institutions. Below we discuss a few of the relevant considerations.

Where should platforms draw the line between legitimate expression and debate, and harmful mis- and disinformation? This has been a deeply fraught question in countries around the world, in part because societies themselves have drawn these lines in different ways. In essence, this is because there are different, often competing, principles at stake.

Platforms can and must do more. There are rival democratic values around freedom of expression and deliberation. Many countries want people to be free to express themselves as part of their democratic participation. At the same time, these societies also know that misinformation and disinformation harm the quality of information in the public sphere, and therefore the public's ability to reflect on political issues – even as hate speech and propaganda limit democratic inclusion. In some countries, such as the United States, the law protects the strong right of expression vis-à-vis the *government*, while letting private actors draw their own lines in some important respects (see Franks 2020). In other

countries, especially those that have dealt with ethnic and racial violence such as Rwanda and Germany, the state has stronger restrictions against hate speech, given the capacity for social violence.

There are many different perspectives on expression that we are not going to resolve here. Broadly, global platforms have developed their own content rules governing things such as mis- and disinformation and hate speech, while also honoring the laws and regulations in the countries where they operate. These rules take shape for a variety of reasons. One is for commercial reasons: platform companies strive to grow and monetize their users, and as such need to create environments that people want to be a part of (most people, for instance, do not want to be exposed to racist content or medical disinformation). Another is for values: many US-based platform companies have their origins in particularly libertarian, “free speech” cultures. There are also social norms and values in the countries platforms operate in, to which they adapt their policies. And, of course, there are national laws governing types of speech and expression (such as defamation, child pornography, false advertising, deceptive business practices, discriminatory pricing, etc.) that platforms often have to adhere to (although in the United States, platforms are shielded from liability for the things their users post in many instances, under a law called Section 230 described above).

Platforms have many different approaches to speech regulation, so many that we cannot adequately cover them here, so we will discuss a company that has had *multiple* approaches toward expression, public health, and democracy – in a comparatively short amount of time. As already detailed in [Chapter 9](#), Meta, the company behind Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp, has extensive Community Standards and an independent Facebook Oversight Board that provides review over content-related decisions. Much of Meta’s policy approach was driven on a case-by-case basis – at least initially – which emerged in response to specific *problems*. These included grappling with what constituted acceptable nudity versus pornography. Think about breastfeeding, for instance, photos of which were initially banned on the platform until mothers around the world successfully challenged this policy on the grounds it was a natural act central to human biology and reproduction. Hate speech is banned by Meta as part of a commitment to creating an inclusive environment among users across its platforms, although its definition and prohibitions have continually evolved in response to new threats and changes in language – even as activists and journalists continually point out that the company does not do nearly enough to tackle the global scale of the problem, and especially lacks adequate language and country-specific expertise in developing nations. Indeed, an international United Nations report clearly implicated the company for its culpability in the ethnic cleansing of Rohingya Muslims, as detailed above, and in 2022 Facebook approved ads calling for ethnic cleansing during elections in Kenya (Cameron 2022).

In the end, there are no easy or clear answers. One of the authors of this book has argued that platforms can do a few things in the attempt to balance expression and democracy (Kreiss et al. 2021). The first is to create clear, democracy-worthy policies that account for national political contexts, including differences between dominant and marginalized groups. “Democracy-worthy” refers to policies that protect key democratic institutions such as elections, the peaceful transfer of power, and censuses, and strongly counter political and civil violence. Platforms can also hold political and social elites to higher standards, not lower ones, given the unique role elites potentially play in fomenting violence, declines in political tolerance, and delegitimizing elections. These policies must

also be race/ethnicity conscious, informed by a clear understanding of power dynamics (in other words, speech that challenges dominant groups should not be treated the same as speech that targets subordinate ones). Platforms must develop clear procedures and enforcement mechanisms, including having adjudication processes for transparency and accountability over moderation decisions (this can also happen through third parties such as the Facebook Oversight Board). Finally, platforms should develop clear rules around data access for third-party accountability to ensure that policies, procedures, and enforcement are fair.

Among those important third parties are journalists. Global journalism plays a different role than platforms with respect to mis- and disinformation and propaganda. Rather than being in a position to take down content (or make decisions to leave it up), journalists have the opportunity to put public pressure on platforms, root out violations of policies, and bring issues to the attention of policymakers and regulatory agencies. As a part of public knowledge-producing institutions, journalists produce reliable content; hold platforms, politicians, and other political actors to account; and articulate the values and commitments of the democratic public. To take one example of these roles for journalists, in the past decade we have seen the international growth of the fact-checking movement – originating in the United States but now with global reach – which has taken a new, aggressive stance toward the truth in political claims. Think for a moment about how this represents a clear commitment for journalists. A contending professional journalism value is “balance,” as is a commitment to representing many different sides of issues, regardless of whether they are grounded in fact or are consistent with democracy.

In reality, journalists often do a bit of all these things. Journalists, even those most committed to professional ideas such as “objectivity,” have long drawn lines around what is allowed to have an airing in their outlets – such as choosing not to cover explicitly racist arguments or repeat hate speech in news coverage. Journalists often balance public interest in the speeches of elected representatives or those vying for public office with a concern over the danger of lies and falsehoods. The different orientations of journalists are also shaped by the many different varieties of media. Some countries, such as those in Scandinavia, are anchored by large public service broadcasters that provide a (relatively) shared set of information and stories about political life that people of all political persuasions orient toward. In other countries, there are more competitive partisan media systems that various political interests use to mobilize political constituencies to advance policy and other aims. Still others are oriented toward large, professional non-partisan commercial newspapers. In many countries, we also see a very important role for racial/ethnic media that have helped to organize along the lines of political identity and interests.

An unresolved tension with respect to the role of journalism and mis- and disinformation is the degree to which more organized media themselves can be the source of things that we find epistemologically dubious. This includes disinformation, lies, and hate speech from political leaders and elected officials that is often amplified through routine media coverage that would be defensible under many journalistic standards (Donovan & boyd 2021; Phillips & Milner 2021). Even worse, in much journalistic coverage of the non-factcheck variety, the truth status of these claims is often unquestioned, which means it might be legitimated in the minds of the public. And the process of establishing just what constitutes the “truth” is often far harder than many would allow. Meanwhile, as detailed above, much of the conflict in countries is often the result of fundamental underlying

contests over power and status, contests that will not be resolved so easily by correcting mis- and disinformation – the latter of which, as detailed above, is often a tool. The reality is that, no matter how much countries would like to imagine that the tensions they experience are a result of media, the larger dynamics underlying mis- and disinformation are fundamental contests over power, status, citizenship, and the right to determine the future of countries. Journalism might tell these stories, but ultimately they are articulating ideas that provide frameworks for clashes in identity.

As such, given all of these considerations, as a prominent report has argued, rather than rely on after-the-fact takedowns of MDP, democratic societies should focus on building collective resilience to attempts at manipulation and produce more high-quality information for the public sphere (The Royal Society 2022). Global journalism and other knowledge-producing institutions have an important, indeed central, role to play in that.

10.8 Summary

Finally, there is so much we do not know about MDP. As we will return to in greater detail in [Chapter 12](#), limiting politics to the ostensibly political – such as campaigns for office, formal elections and political organizations, and institutions such as parties – likely misses most of the sources of MDP in the world. Why? Because entertainment media, religious groups, social clubs – virtually any social gathering – are sources of political information and support political identities. While there has been some research into how these things “spill over” into politics, it is likely that we are still only at the very beginning of our understanding of the forces that shape the political world, including the narratives that shape what people believe are legitimate relations and values to hold.

Discussion Questions

- Clickbait practices help to spread MDP. How would you use clickbait to lure people into reading this chapter?
- What are potential dangers associated with “deep fakes” in the context of political communication? How could they be remedied or avoided?

Suggestions for Further Reading

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